PRODUCT DISCOVERY

From Output to Outcome

Why product ownership is a different discipline from project management, and why the goal is as little output as possible for as much outcome as possible.

Products are not projects

Digital products are never really finished. Unlike a physical product with a fixed manufacturing process, software evolves continuously, often for years, adapting to changing needs. This is why product ownership is a fundamentally different discipline from project management.

A project has a defined start and end date, a fixed scope, and usually a single customer. Success is measured by hitting the deadline, staying within budget and delivering the agreed scope. A product, by contrast, has no natural end date. It serves multiple customer groups whose needs shift over time, and it carries a much wider set of risks that need continuous attention.

Output and outcome

This distinction matters because it changes what we optimise for. Everything between an idea and something working and shippable is called output: features, tickets, releases. What happens once that output reaches real people is called outcome: a change in behaviour, in satisfaction, in business results. A Product Owner's job is not to produce more output faster. It is to produce as little output as possible while creating as much outcome as possible.

This reframing is the foundation for all the resources in this collection. Every method they cover, from opportunity framing to story mapping to prioritisation, exists to help a team spend its limited capacity on the work most likely to create real impact, rather than simply working through a queue of requests.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/product-ownership/from-output-to-outcome

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